

Ontological choices in affective science

Or why I invited David to join us in Santiago

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Ontological choices

Ontological choices in science abound.

- Which classifications and categories make sense for scientific practice?
- Which properties (among many) do we pick as **relevant** for classificatory practices?

Ludwig (2016) claims that these decisions involve **non-epistemic values**.

- How we classify things and accept inductive inferences as justified depends on various commitments (e.g., what we want to do and why we want to do it).

Questions

What are the **ontological choices** that must be made in **affective science**?

How are these ontological choices **value-laden**?

What **consequences** follow from their value-ladenness?

Claims

There is a **basic ontological choice** concerning the role of **biology** in emotion theory.

- Should emotions be classified in virtue of their biology or in virtue of something else?

This decision is **value-laden** because it concerns **similarities/differences between human groups** and **between humans and other species**.

Universalism can be accounted for in terms of **partially overlapping ontologies**.

- There are still some challenges to iron out (**proxy/target properties**).

Theories of emotions

Emotions can be categorized in various ways.

Biological accounts

Emotions can be categorized by non-social or non-cultural factors.

- Neurophysiological mechanisms (BET)
- Functional patterns

Constructionist accounts

Emotions must be categorized by social or cultural factors.

- Social constructionism
- Psychological constructionism

Biological accounts

Emotions can be categorized by non-social or non-cultural factors.

Favors the view that the same **emotions can be identified across cultures**.

- Hypotheses concerning **neurophysiological mechanisms** present in all humans.
- Research on recognition and production of **specific facial and bodily expressions**.

Regards **linguistic** and **social variations** as secondary.

- Culture **modifies** natural processes (and vice versa).

Constructionist accounts

Emotions must be categorized by social or cultural factors.

Favors the view that **emotions are culturally dependent**.

- Emphasizes **linguistic** and **social differences**.
- Undermines **neurophysiological specificity**, highlighting **variability**.

Regards **neurophysiological** patterns as **irrelevant**.

- Whatever activity is observed **does not concern emotions**.

Are emotions natural kinds?

There are two main arguments against the idea that emotions form **natural kinds**.

Griffiths (1997):

What Emotions Really Are

There are various theories of emotions which describe different subsets of emotions:

- Basic emotions (affect programs)
- Higher cognitive emotions
- Socially sustained pretenses

Barrett (2006):

"Are Emotions Natural Kinds"

There is no specificity or consistency in mechanisms for each emotion.

Emotions do not form natural kinds (understood **biologically**).

Griffiths, P. E. (1997). *What Emotions Really Are: The Problem of Psychological Categories*. University of Chicago Press.

Barrett, L. F. (2006). Are Emotions Natural Kinds?. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 1(1), 28–58.

Functionalism

Metaphysically, we can account for **variability** by constructing **functional kinds**.¹

- Emotions are individuated by **behavioral patterns**.
- **Neurophysiological variability** is a case of **multiple realizability**.

Consequences:

- Lack of biological specificity **does not entail constructionism**.
- Emotional taxonomy **depends on behavioral classification**.

¹Loaiza, J. R. (2024). Functionalism and the Emotions. *The British Journal for the Philosophy of Science*, 75(1), 233–251.

"Natural kinds"?

Is the concept of **natural kind** useful to understand the classification of emotions?

Ludwig (2018) argues that we should **let go** of the concept of "natural kind".

- The explanandum is not (necessarily) metaphysical unity, but **nonarbitrary classification**.
- Different theories of natural kinds show different ways in which classification can be nonarbitrary.

Functionalism accounts for metaphysical variability, but **does not explain** nonarbitrary classification.

Fixing the explanandum

To understand how to classify emotions, we need to get a grip on **what is it that we are classifying**.¹

Folk emotion concepts offer a pretheoretical conceptual framework to start with.

- They **ostensively** pick out the phenomena of interest.
- They point to **observable patterns** that enable theorizing.

We can construct **scientific emotion concepts** by **explicating** folk emotion concepts.

¹Loaiza, J. R. (2025). Investigating the Fundamental Base of Emotion Science. *Passion: Journal of the European Philosophical Society for the Study of Emotions*, 3(1), 52–67.

Cross-cultural worries

Are “folk emotion concepts” a **unified category**?

There is ample evidence of **cultural variation** in emotion vocabularies.

- Category mismatch (e.g., shame/embarrassment vs. vergüenza, sadness vs. grust/pečál)
- Backtranslation problems
- Untranslatable emotions (e.g., saudade, Schadenfreude)

Anglocentrism

Talk of "*the* folk emotion concepts" reifies Anglocentric emotion categories.

It is as though theorists have implicitly assumed that (at least) English lexicalizes all of the basic emotions, and their favorite candidates are the referents of high-frequency English emotion words such as "anger," "fear," "enjoyment" (i.e., "happiness"?), "sadness," "disgust," and "surprise." How fortunate that the search for basic emotions was not undertaken by Tahitian or Sarawak psychologists. (Ortony, 2022)

Against naïve universalism

The traditional strategy in affective science is to look for **biological universals**.

Evidence for and against universals is **evidentially underdetermined**.

- Similarity judgments are always against the **backdrop** of **dominant categories**.¹
- The question cannot be settled by **evidential considerations alone**.

Universalism (or relativism) is a **value-laden ontological choice**.

¹Loaiza, J. R. (2025). Cultural Variation of Emotions and Radical Relativism. *Theory & Psychology*, 35(4), 444–465.

Universalism as a value-laden choice

Universalism (or relativism) depends on **how do we relate to other human beings**.

- Assume we all share the same emotional capacities?
- Can we understand each other across cultures?

These are **ontological negotiations** to be had considering **social-epistemic structures**.

Emotions in nonhuman animals

Do nonhuman animals also have similar emotional capacities?

- Morgan's Canon is a value-laden choice.
- We should enable **hypotheses** projecting over **behavioral similarities** despite phylogenetic variability.¹

Universalism not only extends across cultures, but also across species.

¹Loaiza, J. R. (2022). Non-Human Animal Emotions: Homological or Functional Kinds?. *Perspectiva Filosófica*, 49(5), 52.

Universalism as ontological overlap

Ludwig & El-Hani (2026) argue that we should demystify ontological difference by noting **property clusters**.

- A kind K may cluster properties $\{P, Q, R, S, T\}$
- Different knowledge systems may note some of these properties:
 - $S_1 : \{P, Q, R\}$
 - $S_2 : \{R, S, T\}$

If S_1 and S_2 co-identify enough properties, we have an **overlapping ontology**.

Universalism as ontological overlap

For each emotion kind E , we can search for overlapping properties.

- Similarities in identified properties (e.g., behavioral patterns).
- Differences in representational and pragmatic needs.

We assume potential universal emotions and revise empirically which properties obtain.

- No in-principle reason for intrinsically localized emotions.
- Differences accounted for as differences in needs.

Challenges for emotion science

The ontological overlaps framework works well for properties that we can **triangulate**.

- Point to objects that have this property and verify intersubjectively.
- No (alleged) authority of first-person intuitions.

Emotions are **not like this**.

- We cannot easily triangulate on experiential properties.
- Biological properties are controversial.
- People argue for their intuitions in how emotions are **defined**.

Challenges for emotion science

We not only need to account for property clusters, but also distinguish **proxy** and **target** properties.

- Consider behavioral patterns.
 - Target properties of emotions?
 - Or proxies for some other target property (e.g., experience, appraisals)?

Distinguishing proxy/target properties also involves ontological choices to be made.

In sum

Affective science faces a **basic ontological choice**: should emotions be classified by their biology or by something else?

- The choice cannot be settled on **evidential grounds alone**.
- It is **value-laden**, and concerns how we relate across **cultures** and **species**.

We need a discussion on how to make these **ontological choices**.

- How should we account for similarity and differences across cultures?

In sum

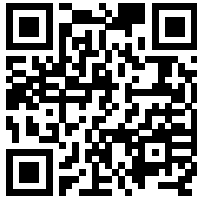
Overlapping ontologies offer an alternative to the universalism/relativism debate.

- Universal emotions assumed and revised through property triangulation.
- Differences are accounted for as differences in **representational and pragmatic needs**.

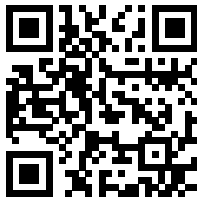
There are challenges to apply this framework to affective science.

- Difficulties in triangulation
- Intuition and presumed authority in definition of emotion concepts.

Thank you!



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